



DECISIVE MOMENT September 11, 2001 08:46 a.m.

9/11

On September 11, 2001, 19 Islamic extremists launched attacks on the World Trade Center in New York City and the Pentagon in Washington, D.C., killing thousands. This strike by members of the Al-Qaeda terrorist network on symbols of Western power shocked the world. It led to an American declaration of “War on Terror” to end international terrorism.

At 8:46 a.m. local time, American Airlines Flight 11 crashed into the north tower of the World Trade Center, killing the 92 people on board—and killing or trapping a further 1,366 people at or above the point of impact. News teams rushed to the scene. Initial reports described the crash as a terrible accident but when, just 16 minutes later, news cameras witnessed United Airlines Flight 175 crashing into the center’s south tower, it was clear that the US was under attack.

The hijackers, who were mainly Saudi-Arabian nationals, had taken over the California-bound flights soon after takeoff from East Coast airports. They used knives, mace, and the threat of bombs to subdue crews and passengers, then directed the fuel-laden jets toward their targets.

In the north tower, all routes down were cut off. People trapped inside made desperate calls to loved ones, begging for help or simply saying farewell. Around the world, millions watched the awful sight of people hurling themselves from the burning building. In the south tower one staircase was undamaged. Just 18 of the 600 people trapped in the

building walked to safety before the tower collapsed. At 10:28 a.m., the north tower also fell.

Flight controllers became aware that two more planes had been hijacked but were unable to locate them before 9:37 a.m., when American Airlines Flight 77 crashed into the Pentagon, headquarters of the US Department of Defense, killing a further 189 people. At 10:03 a.m., United Airlines Flight 93 crashed into a field near Shanksville, Pennsylvania, killing all those on board. Cell phone records and evidence from black box recorders reveal that passengers, alerted to the fate of other hijacked planes by phone calls, planned to charge the cockpit and attack their hijackers. Although the passengers could not break into the cockpit, they did succeed in diverting the hijackers from their intended target, almost certainly the Capitol Building or White House in Washington, D.C. During the final minutes of the Flight 93 recordings the hijackers can be heard deciding to abort their mission and crash the plane. As the plane hurtles toward the ground, the terrorists are praying fervently.

New York terror attacks

The World Trade Center, a great symbol of American wealth and power, moments after hijackers crashed their planes into its twin towers.

“Today, our fellow citizens, **our way of life, our very freedom came under attack.”**

PRESIDENT GEORGE W. BUSH ADDRESSING THE NATION, SEPTEMBER 11, 2001